

To ensure that innovation is truly inclusive, the **UTTHAN** was launched under the Manthan platform. While Manthan allows anyone to propose or solve problems, initially most projects were taken up by premier institutions such as IITs and IISc, which already had strong reputations and resources. This limited opportunities for many capable colleges in smaller cities.

UTTHAN was created to bridge this gap by empowering **Tier 2 and Tier 3 institutions** and integrating them into the national innovation ecosystem. The initiative focuses on building capacity through exposure, mentorship, and partnerships, enabling these institutions to compete effectively and contribute meaningfully to technology development.

Experienced industry partners collaborate with these colleges to guide them in developing strong project proposals, executing impactful research, and delivering practical solutions. UTTHAN is helping create a more balanced innovation landscape, ensuring that talent and ideas from across India contribute to the country's scientific and technological advancement.

How do you bring startups, industries, and innovators together, particularly in Tier 2 and Tier 3 colleges?

To connect startups, industries, and innovators effectively in Tier 2 and Tier 3 colleges and universities, we have established **MITTI Innovation Hubs**.

MITTI stands for Manthan, International Federation of Inventors' Associations, Industries, Tier 2 and Tier 3 Colleges, Technologies, and Innovation. It is an integrated hub for research, innovation, startup incubation, pilot projects, and investor engagement, serving as a single platform that connects startups, industries, investors, and research institutions across India,

including smaller towns and semi-urban areas.

MITTI supports the full innovation cycle, from idea generation to commercialisation. Its objective is not only to promote strong ideas but to help convert them into products and solutions that address real societal needs. Through MITTI, startups can test ideas through pilot projects, gather real-world feedback, and connect with industry partners and investors to scale their solutions.

The hub also emphasises mentorship and capacity-building, offering guidance from experienced experts across sectors. Ultimately, MITTI aims to improve the success rate of Indian startups by providing a complete support ecosystem from discovery to market readiness, bridging the gap between innovation and implementation.

What are the Rural Smart Village Centres, and how do they function at the village level?

The Rural Smart Village Centres (RSVCs) bring technology and innovation directly to rural communities, ensuring that advancements reach farmers at the grassroots level.

Each 1000sqft (92.9sqm) centre showcases technologies from the RuTAG programme and other initiatives, offering live demonstrations and hands-on guidance. RSVCs operate across twelve verticals, covering areas such as agriculture, livelihoods, and education, and provide services including satellite-based farming advice and rapid soil testing.

By using these affordable machines and technologies, farmers can increase productivity while saving time and reducing costs. The centres also support villagers in accessing government schemes related to agriculture, education, and assistive technologies.

Set up with private support, RSVCs are designed to become

self-sustaining through nominal service fees.

How do your initiatives aim to empower women and strengthen their role in India's science and innovation ecosystem?

Our initiatives aim to empower women by strengthening their presence and leadership in India's science and innovation ecosystem. One such initiative is the **Women in STEM programme**. This key initiative focuses on increasing women's participation and retention in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics.

India already has a strong base, with about 44 per cent of women in STEM up to the postgraduate level—one of the highest rates globally. However, participation drops to around 24 to 26 per cent beyond the postgraduate level, as many women leave the system due to social, professional, or personal factors.

The programme seeks to address this gap and ensure that trained women professionals continue contributing to science and technology.

To achieve this, multiple departments, including the Department of Science and Technology, the Department of Biotechnology, CSIR, and ICMR, have launched dedicated initiatives such as the **KIRAN programme**.

Under the Manthan platform, the Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser has introduced complementary efforts that recognise and support women in STEM. These include publishing coffee-table books on women achievers in science, hosting lecture series with institutions such as IIT Delhi, and partnering with philanthropic organisations to mentor and sponsor female students from rural backgrounds pursuing STEM education.

The broader goal of the Women in STEM initiative is to empower women as scientists, innovators, and leaders across disciplines. The current focus is on providing